MY MEDIEVAL LIFE

WORLD DESIGN RULES — EXPANDED REFERENCE AND EXAMPLES

Annotated companion to the original approved Version 1.0 | 16 rules | 19 October 2026

"If I can't get lost in my own game, it's not alive enough."

Authority and scope

The mandatory rules below are reproduced from the original 16-rule Word document. Added examples and verification scenarios draw on the project directions and reported Build 14 findings. They illustrate desired behavior, not verified implementation. Preserve numbering 001–016; any newer rules 017–019 remain separate.

Original purpose and enforcement

- These are enduring design requirements, not a Build 11 punch list. New content and refactors must honor them. The existing Interlocking Systems Manifest remains the authoritative dependency record and must be maintained during development. This document specifies desired behavior; it does not certify that any feature has already been implemented.
- Maintain unique identifiers for materials, recipes, professions, factions, NPCs, relationships and system interactions. Update the existing manifest as changes are made.
- Build player-facing wiki content from authoritative game data where practical; avoid divergent manual copies of recipes and mechanics.
- Test connected gameplay loops, not just isolated features. Validate NPC autonomy, resource deductions, economy, save/load and multi-generation persistence.
- Use periodic or event-driven NPC planning rather than expensive per-frame full-world decision-making.
- Treat the numerical material-coverage thresholds as mandatory for standard materials. Document and justify exceptions for genuinely specialized materials.

Rule 001 — Material Interdependency

- Every standard crafting material must be consumed by at least three meaningfully different recipes across at least two distinct professions.
- Track recipe count, consuming professions and any approved exceptions per material in the Interlocking Systems Manifest.
- Automatically flag materials below either threshold.

Expanded design example: Planks can build a named house, a cart, and furniture across professions. The Downs-to-Miller gift of 30 planks must actually move and be consumed.

Verification scenario: Audit every standard material for three distinct recipes and two professions; test actual deductions.

Rule 002 — Professional Interdependency

- Every production profession must supply at least one good or resource required by a different profession.
- Model cross-profession demand so trades form production chains instead of isolated menus.

Expanded design example: Grain moves from farmer to miller to baker to household. Timber moves through harvest, carpentry and cart construction.

Verification scenario: Run a complete chain with inventories, payment, shortages and demand.

Rule 003 — Meaningful Recipes

- Recipes must produce practical, distinct gameplay value.

- Cosmetic variants or near-duplicate recipes must not be counted solely to satisfy Rule 001.

Expanded design example: A cart enables hauling, a stairway opens a route, and medicine treats illness; three differently colored carts are not three meaningful recipes.

Verification scenario: Document distinct gameplay purpose for every counted recipe.

Rule 004 — Economic Consequences

- Supply, shortages, production and trade must influence prices, availability, jobs and behavior across professions.
- Scarcity and surpluses should produce observable responses rather than decorative statistics.

Expanded design example: Depleted iron and coal affect smithing, prices, employment and imports; manor labor reserves and caravan money caps alter the same economy.

Verification scenario: Compare 100- and 365-day simulations, including wealth, jobs, supplies and trade.

Rule 005 — Living World Independence

- NPCs, households and businesses must continue making economic and personal decisions without player initiation.
- The village must evolve during ordinary gameplay even when the player does not intervene.

Expanded design example: With no player intervention, households eat, work, trade, pursue housing and change over generations.

Verification scenario: Idle-player test: verify independent transactions, decisions, construction attempts and persistence.

Rule 006 — Interlocking Systems Documentation

- Document every new or changed material, recipe, profession and cross-system dependency in the existing Interlocking Systems Manifest.
- Maintain unique interaction IDs, dependency references and cross-system impact notes; avoid duplicate or orphaned entries.

Expanded design example: A cart touches crafting, ownership, inventory, NPC hauling, pathfinding, trade and saves.

Verification scenario: Validate existing manifest IDs, cross-system references and change impact.

Rule 007 — Automated Compliance

- Generate a material interdependency report from actual recipe data showing recipe and profession coverage.
- Flag violations, broken references and undocumented exceptions during development/integration.

Expanded design example: An automated report flags a material with only two recipes, a profession supplying nobody, or an orphaned recipe.

Verification scenario: Run positive and negative compliance fixtures in CI.

Rule 008 — Player Knowledge and In-Game Wiki

- Provide a comprehensive, accessible in-game wiki with pictures, descriptions, uses, acquisition methods, recipes, professions and related systems.
- Include practical “How do I…?” guides and search/categories.
- Generate factual values from current game data wherever possible; keep guidance synchronized with implemented behavior.

Expanded design example: The wiki explains how to build and use a cart with current ingredients and controls, without presenting future elections as playable.

Verification scenario: Compare wiki values with actual data and test navigation on touch and controller.

Rule 009 — Emergent Gameplay

- Design interactions that create unscripted opportunities, setbacks and stories through shared systems.
- Player choices and NPC actions should have second-order consequences across the world.

Expanded design example: Thomas Downs donates 30 planks to William Miller; the planks build a specific house. Descendants can recall the gift if family knowledge passed down.

Verification scenario: Test provenance, transfer, construction, generations, dialogue, save/load and consequences.

Rule 010 — Depth Without Obscurity

- Make complexity arise from meaningful mechanics, not confusing UI or hidden rules.
- Give players usable explanations, feedback and tools without forcing a single career or playstyle.

Expanded design example: Sword reach and attack timing should be understandable without overlapping sprites. Obstructed cart routes should show useful feedback.

Verification scenario: Playtest clarity and responsiveness on keyboard, phone and controller.

Rule 011 — NPC Self-Improvement and Prosperity

- Every NPC must pursue a better life according to their personality, means, age, circumstances and ambitions.
- Track five aspiration domains: food/security, money/wealth, goods/property, professional growth, and family/household development.
- Priorities must change after successes and setbacks; NPCs may fail, be content, or choose different definitions of success.
- Link ambitions to actual purchases, production, relationships, housing, inheritance and employment.

Expanded design example: An NPC may prioritize food, then wealth, property and family; another may prefer stability. Heirs do not automatically inherit ancestor skills.

Verification scenario: Test five aspiration domains and adaptation after illness, loss, marriage or prosperity.

Rule 012 — NPC Competition and Economic Rivalry

- NPCs, households and businesses compete for employment, customers, workers, materials, land, property, contracts and social advancement.
- Competitors respond to market conditions through pricing, specialization, expansion, relocation, hiring or business failure.
- The player participates in the same competitive economy and receives no automatic preferential treatment.

Expanded design example: Two carpenters compete for timber, customers and workers, adjusting prices or specializing in carts.

Verification scenario: Test market response, hiring, failure and equal rules for player and NPCs.

Rule 013 — Finite Resources and Actual Consumption

- Households and businesses must draw goods from real inventories and money from real budgets; no infinite or purely decorative production.
- Deduct inputs for food, fuel, smithing, carpentry, farming, livestock, construction and household growth.
- Support harvesting, production, imports, replenishment and believable regeneration alongside depletion and overuse.
- Scarcity must affect market prices and NPC behavior; consequences and inventory changes must persist through save/load.

Expanded design example: Thirty planks leave the donor inventory, enter recipient stock and are consumed once; mines and wildlife face finite depletion.

Verification scenario: Run conservation, save/load and long-run resource exhaustion/recovery tests.

Rule 014 — Graveyards, Ancestry and NPC Legacy

- Every deceased NPC must leave a persistent historical record and a named headstone in a graveyard.
- Headstone interaction must display birth/death dates, occupations, career milestones, accomplishments, family links and important life events.
- Include a remembrance attributed to an actual family member, friend, rival or community member, consistent with recorded relationships and events.
- Support linked family trees, multiple generations, expanding burial grounds and historical records without retaining full active-NPC simulation state.
- Political, criminal and professional careers must remain visible in memorial biographies.

Expanded design example: A grave records William Miller's dates, family, profession, named house, recorded deed and remembrance by a knowledgeable relative.

Verification scenario: Persist family trees, historical facts, graves and memorials across generations.

Rule 015 — Political Authority, Social Hierarchy and Civic Employment

- Settlements must support appropriately scaled governance: mayor/elder, council, guard captain, guards, tax collector, bailiff/magistrate, clerks/stewards and household servants as applicable.
- Officials must perform actual work affecting taxes, law, security, construction, public spending, property and trade.
- Use an actual public treasury with revenue from taxes, fees, fines, rents or duties and expenditures for wages, infrastructure and supplies.
- Leadership must change by locally appropriate succession methods such as election, appointment, council selection or inheritance.
- NPCs and players may seek office or advancement; wealth, influence, reputation, family and public service should matter without guaranteeing success.
- Guards must patrol, investigate and respond to crimes based on funding, staffing and equipment.
- Domestic workers must have real duties, needs, compensation/support and opportunities; preserve political careers in historical records.

Expanded design example: Every eligible NPC votes individually for mayor using memory, interests and policy; a finite treasury funds guards and civic work.

Verification scenario: Count ballots and verify budgets, offices, patrols, elections and succession.

Rule 016 — Bandit Factions, Criminal Careers and Outlaw Leadership

- Banditry must be a playable profession and autonomous NPC career, not only hostile enemy spawning.
- Support criminal activities such as theft, burglary, robbery, livestock theft, smuggling, raiding and fencing stolen goods with consequences.
- Allow players and NPCs to discover/join bandit factions, meet entry requirements, build faction reputation and rise through ranks.
- Provide leadership challenges through duels, faction support or other faction-specific methods; failure must carry consequences.
- Leaders must manage recruitment, roles, hideouts, inventories, loot division, raids, supplies, territory and faction relations.
- Track distinct reputations among bandits, villagers and guards; authorities respond with patrols, investigations, bounties or enforcement.
- Bandits require real food, money, equipment and shelter; factions can split, change leaders, dissolve, recruit or persist without the player.
- Record outlaw careers, relationships and succession in the historical and graveyard systems.

Expanded design example: A player can join bandits, steal livestock, fence goods, advance, challenge leadership and provision a hideout; NPC factions evolve independently.

Verification scenario: Test crime consequences, faction economy, leadership and guard enforcement.

Original mandatory acceptance checks

- Materials report shows ≥3 distinct consuming recipes and ≥2 professions for every non-exempt standard material.
- Each production profession supplies another; at least one multi-step production chain works end to end.
- NPCs consume real inventory and funds, pursue independent goals, compete and adapt to shortages over extended simulation time.
- Treasury income and expenses, guard staffing, law enforcement and leadership succession change the settlement without player direction.
- A player can join a bandit faction, advance, challenge its leader and manage the faction; NPC factions also progress autonomously.
- Deaths create permanent interactive headstones with accurate career, kinship and relationship-grounded remembrance data.
- Wiki data agrees with actual recipes, materials and profession mechanics.
- Manifest IDs and dependency references validate after changes; save/load preserves world, inventories, family histories and faction/government states.
- Implementation note: This is the approved design specification to hand to agents. Any unimplemented mechanics should be tracked as development work; do not mark rules satisfied solely because the code compiles or a task was checked off.

Additional cross-system validation scenarios

Generational memory

Trace the real 30-plank gift into a named house and record event provenance, family knowledge transmission, descendant dialogue, relationships and individual voting.

Wildlife recovery

Claude reported wildlife at zero after 365 simulated days. Diagnose by species, hunting, breeding and predation; test protected refuges and gradual dispersal without instant respawn.

Population and housing

Claude reported population falling from 100 to 69 and zero new houses over 365 days. Investigate needs, resources, construction, household aspirations and mortality rather than assuming causes.

Real-device testing

Automated tests do not establish Android touch, physical controller or Windows performance. Verify controls, UI, save/load and consistent test signing.

Source and evidence boundaries

Primary source: My_Medieval_Life_World_Design_Rules_v1.docx, dated 19 October 2026. Expanded scenarios are based on user-approved project directions and the development reports shared in conversation. Reported simulation outcomes are not independently verified in this document. All unimplemented work belongs in the permanent requirements register.